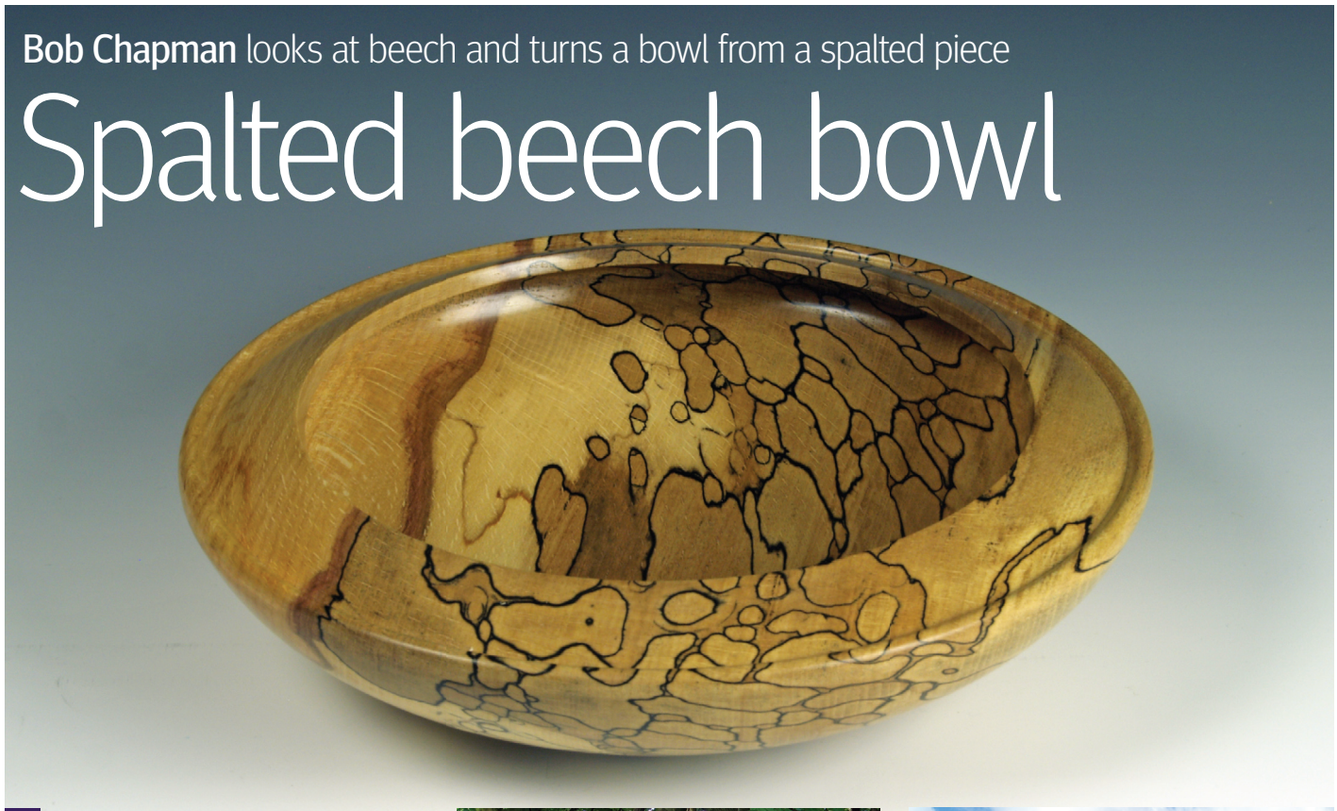
Bob Chapman looks at beech and turns a bowl from a spalted piece

Spalted beech bowl



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After teaching chemistry for many years, Bob took early retirement to become a professional woodturner, and is a member of the Register of Professional Turners. He was a demonstrator at the 2009 AWGB Woodturning Seminar and is available for commissions.

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Large and impressive trees, beeches (*Fagus sylvatica*) often show themselves off well by preventing other plants from growing beneath them. They prefer a well-drained soil and then take even more moisture from it by means of their dense root systems. This, and the deep shade cast by their extensive leaf canopy, can make the area beneath them inhospitable to all but the toughest of other plants.

Beech trees seem equally at home in woodland or parkland and the biggest examples are often to be found where there are no competing trees nearby. In these more exposed positions the trees may develop significant buttresses at the base of the trunk, perhaps to better withstand the onslaught of winter gales. Amongst our most common trees, beeches are encountered on almost any walk in town or in the countryside, and they contribute much to the tranquillity of many a country footpath. Beech's pinkish-brown timber has a close, even texture with a tight grain that works easily and will take fine detail. It is widely used for furniture and is an ideal wood for turning. In the kitchen many small utensils such as spatulas and spoons are still made from beech and in the past it was widely used to make bowls, platters and plates for domestic use.

Not many plants are able to grow in the shade underneath beech trees

Beech trees grow to a large size when there are no other trees surrounding them

Beech is susceptible to spalting

Beech is particularly susceptible to spalting, a fungal attack that leads to the formation of irregular black lines and areas of pale creamy coloured wood. The fungal attack only occurs in timber with a high – greater than about 20% – moisture content, and stops when the wood dries out. Spalted timber is much prized and may command high prices, but if allowed to spalt for too long it becomes soft and crumbly and almost impossible to work to a good surface finish.

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